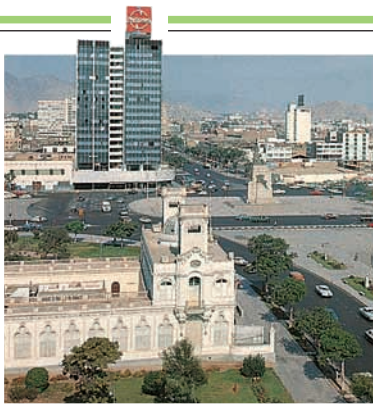




PERU

Capital city: Lima**Area:** 496,223 sq miles
(1,285,200 sq km)**Population:** 27,200,000**Official languages:**
Spanish, Quechua, and Aymará**Major religions:** Christian
95%, other 5%**Government:** Multiparty
democracy**Currency:** New sol**Adult literacy rate:** 85%**Life expectancy:** 70 years**People per doctor:** 1,111**Televisions:** 144 per 1,000
people

LIMA

Gray skies and damp mists hang over Lima for much of the year. But the population of Peru's capital city has grown rapidly to more than 6 million as people have flocked there in search of work. Although the rich live in new apartment buildings or suburban houses, the poor survive in *calampas*, huge, overcrowded shantytowns that have sprung up on the outskirts. Lima was founded in 1535 by the Spaniard Francisco Pizarro.

PERU

FOUR HUNDRED YEARS AGO, Peru was the center of the great Inca Empire, which stretched the length of South America. Descendants of the Incas still continue their traditional way of life in the Andes Mountains, and make up about half of Peru's population. In recent years, unemployment, poverty, and other social problems have led to much political violence in Peru. This has prevented foreign investment in Peru and kept it one of the poorest countries in South America.



PACIFIC FISHING

Peru's coastal waters are teeming with plankton, which provide food for anchovies, sardines, pilchards, and mackerel. Anchovies, caught and processed into fish meal, are a major export. Every nine or 10 years a current of warm water, called *El Niño*, upsets the balance of plankton, and the fish move to better feeding areas. It struck throughout the 1990s, devastating the fishing industry.

The islands are built from layers of reeds that rot away at the bottom and are replaced at the top.

New reeds are cut and stacked, ready for use.

Villagers grow potatoes in fields by the lake.

The Urus build their homes and boats from the totora reeds that grow at the edge of the lake.

Remains of the city of Machu Picchu



Women untangling fishing nets

Women wear their hair in a single braid, which they tuck into their hats.

LAKE TITICACA

Lying 12,500 ft (3,810 m) above sea level, Lake Titicaca is the world's highest navigable lake. It stretches across the border of Peru and into Bolivia. For thousands of years, native peoples have fished its waters. One group, the Urus, live on the lake in villages built on huge rafts made from reeds. They grow potatoes (one of the few crops that will ripen at such high altitudes), catch fish, and hunt birds that live by the lake.

SHINING PATH

During the 1980s a guerilla group called the Shining Path conducted a terrorist campaign in Peru. The group wanted to introduce a communist government and proceeded to terrorize the country. They were able to assassinate people and bomb targets in Peru's cities. Their leader, Abimael Guzmán, was captured in 1992 and later imprisoned.



THE LOST CITY OF THE INCAS
Perched high in the Andes, Machu Picchu was an important Inca city in the 15th and 16th centuries. This fortress city escaped the notice of the Spanish conquerors who arrived in 1532, and it remained a "lost city" until it was rediscovered by American archeologist Hiram Bingham in 1911. The site includes the remains of ceremonial buildings, such as temples, and 143 homes.

Find out more

ANDES: 40, 58

CITIES (OVERCROWDING): 17

NATIVE PEOPLES: 43

POTATOES: 140

The Urus build boats from tightly bundled reeds. A well-built boat can last a family up to six months.